on civilians, encounter killings, disappearances, torture camps, etc . . . These are the realities that a Kashmiri grows up with. People outside Kashmir have no clue what Indian security forces are up to in Kashmir.

Even if they kill me for no crime of mine, it would be because they cannot stand the truth. They cannot face the questions that arise out of hanging a Kashmiri without [a fair trial].

An ear-splitting electric bell rang. I could hear hurried last-minute conversations from the neighbouring cubicles. I put my last question to Afzal.

What do you want to be known as?

(He thinks for a minute.) As Afzal, as Mohmammad Afzal. I am Afzal for Kashmiris, and I am Afzal for Indians as well, but the two groups have entirely conflicting perceptions of my being. I would naturally trust the judgment of Kashmiri people not only because I am one of them but also because they are well aware of the reality that I have been through and they cannot be misled into believing any distorted version of either history or an incident.

I was confused with this last statement, but on further reflection I began to understand what Afzal meant. The true history of Kashmir and the facts behind any ugly incident involving a Kashmiri always shock an Indian whose sources of knowledge on Kashmir are confined only to text books and media reports. Afzal had just done that to me.

Two more bells. Time to end the mulaqat. But people were still busy conversing. The mikes were put off. People finally stopped speaking. But I could see his lips still moving, and strained to hear. The guards came up, roughly asking people to leave. They put the lights out. The mulaqat room turned dark.

In the long walk out from Jail No 3 of the Tihar compound to the main road, I found myself among clusters of twos and threes, moving out silently—a cluster of mother, wife and daughter; or brother, sister and wife; or friend and brother; or no relation at all. Every cluster had two things in common. They carried empty cotton bags and the bags had food stains on them, the result, most probably, of rough frisking by the special police. And they all wore inexpensive winter clothes, many had torn shoes, and outside Gate No 3